

CORTORA

Return Windows, Conditions, and Exceptions

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COR-PL-011	2.0	Order Operations	Internal	01 September 2026	Annual

This policy defines how long customers have to return a product, the conditions a returned product must meet, and the exceptions where a return is not accepted. It applies to physical products sold through the Cortora marketplace and is used by Customer Experience, Order Operations, and OpsPilot when evaluating a return request.

This policy governs the **return process itself**. Whether a return ultimately results in a refund, and how much is refunded, is governed by the Refund Policy.

1. Standard Return Window

Product category	Standard return window	Window starts from
Consumer electronics (phones, tablets, laptops, audio)	30 calendar days	Date of delivery
Home-office equipment (monitors, chairs, desks)	30 calendar days	Date of delivery
Smart-home accessories (plugs, sensors, hubs)	30 calendar days	Date of delivery
Consumables and accessories sold as sealed items (cables, cases)	14 calendar days, unopened only	Date of delivery
Made-to-order or personalised items	Not eligible for standard return	Not applicable

Where a customer resides in a jurisdiction with a statutory right of withdrawal that is longer than the windows above, the statutory right applies. Support Agents should escalate jurisdiction-specific questions to a Support Manager rather than guessing at the applicable statutory period.

2. Conditions for an Acceptable Return

- The item is returned within the applicable window in Section 1.
- The item is complete, including cables, remotes, manuals, and original accessories that shipped with it.
- The item is not damaged in a way that is inconsistent with reasonable inspection and testing.
- For items with serial numbers or activation identifiers, the identifier on the returned item matches the identifier recorded against the original order.
- Original packaging is included where reasonably possible; missing packaging alone does not disqualify a return but may result in a condition-based deduction under Section 4.

3. Return Reason Categories

Reason code	Description	Typical handling
CHANGE_OF_MIND	Customer no longer wants the item; no fault with the product.	Standard return window applies; condition-based deduction may apply; customer typically covers return shipping unless local law states otherwise.
DAMAGED_ON_ARRIVAL	Item was already damaged when the box was opened.	Expedited return; no restocking deduction; full refund or replacement is prioritized.
DEFECTIVE	Item stopped working or never functioned correctly.	Diagnostic questions may be asked before a return label is issued; warranty terms may apply beyond the standard window.
WRONG_ITEM	Item received does not match what was ordered.	Expedited return; Cortora covers return shipping; full refund or correct replacement.
NO_LONGER_NEEDED	Duplicate purchase, order placed in error, or gift declined.	Standard return window and condition-based deduction apply.

4. Condition-Based Deductions

When a returned item does not meet the full conditions in Section 2, a deduction from the refundable amount may apply rather than an outright rejection of the return, unless the return falls into one of the exceptions in Section 6.

- Missing original accessories or manuals: deduction proportional to the replacement cost of the missing component, as listed in the product catalogue.
- Missing original packaging only, item otherwise in resale condition: minor deduction reflecting reduced resale value, at a rate defined in the current restocking fee schedule maintained by Order Operations.
- Signs of use beyond reasonable inspection and testing (e.g. visible wear, scratches consistent with regular use rather than testing): deduction reflecting reduced resale value, assessed by the returns inspection process.
- Return reasons DAMAGED_ON_ARRIVAL, DEFECTIVE, and WRONG_ITEM are not subject to condition-based deductions caused by the fault itself.

Condition-based deductions must be based on the physical inspection outcome recorded in the Return record, not on an employee's assumption about what a customer likely did with the item.

5. Return Process Overview

- Customer initiates a return request through the storefront or Customer Experience, selecting a reason code.
- The system checks the order's delivery date against the applicable return window for the product category.
- If eligible, a Return record is created with status REQUESTED and a return shipping method is issued.
- The customer ships the item back through the specified carrier; the Return record moves to IN_TRANSIT.
- On arrival at the returns centre, the item is inspected and the Return record moves to INSPECTING.
- The inspection outcome results in ACCEPTED, ACCEPTED_WITH_DEDUCTION, or REJECTED.
- An accepted return triggers a refund evaluation under the Refund Policy.

6. Return Exceptions

The following items are not eligible for standard return, subject to statutory consumer rights that may override these exceptions in some jurisdictions:

- Made-to-order, engraved, or personalised products.
- Digital licence keys, activation codes, or downloadable software once redeemed or activated.
- Hygiene-sensitive accessories (e.g. in-ear audio components) once the seal has been broken, unless defective.
- Items purchased through a business/bulk order channel, which follow separate commercial terms.
- Items reported as DAMAGED_ON_ARRIVAL or DEFECTIVE more than 30 days after the standard return window has closed, which should instead be routed to manufacturer warranty support where applicable.

7. Rejected Returns

A return may be rejected when the inspection finds the item does not match the original order, shows damage inconsistent with the stated reason, or fails to meet the minimum condition for the reason code claimed. A rejected return does not automatically close the case: the customer must be notified of the specific reason, and the item is either returned to the customer or, where the customer agrees, disposed of according to Cortora's environmental handling procedures. Employees must not approve a refund against a REJECTED return without a documented exception approved by a Support Manager.

8. Role of OpsPilot

OpsPilot may help a Support Agent determine the applicable return window, identify the correct reason code, and summarise the inspection outcome once it is recorded in the Return record. OpsPilot must not mark a return as accepted, rejected, or eligible for a deduction on its own; the physical inspection outcome from the returns centre is the authoritative source, and OpsPilot's role is limited to interpreting and explaining that recorded outcome.

9. Related Documents

- Refund Policy — governs whether an accepted return results in a refund and how much.
- Shipping & Delivery Policy — governs return shipping methods and expected transit times.
- Customer Support SOP — governs how Support Agents interact with customers during a return.
- Employee Authorization Matrix — governs who may override a REJECTED return outcome.

Synthetic environment notice: Cortora, its employees, customers, policies, and operational records are fictional and created solely for the OpsPilot engineering project.